Habits of attention

Teaching purposeful listening routines

Use habits of attention to teach where students should direct attention during explanation, modelling and discussion. Each habit needs a learning purpose and a recognisable cue.

How to do it well

1 Explain the learning purpose. Connect the habit to hearing a step, following a model, respecting a speaker or reducing distraction—not obedience for its own sake.

2 Select the highest-value behaviour. Teach only what matters in the current phase, such as tracking a model during explanation or orienting to a peer during discussion.

3 Model and rehearse briefly. Show what the habit looks and sounds like, practise once and return quickly to the learning.

4 Reinforce with short cues. Prompt early and quietly, narrate success occasionally and avoid turning the routine into constant commentary.

5 Apply selectively and adapt the form. Turn the habit off when pupils should read or write; make reasonable adjustments while preserving the attentional purpose.

6 Fade towards independence. Reduce verbal prompts to a gesture or question so pupils increasingly manage their own attention.

What this sounds like

“For this demonstration, put your pen down and attend to the diagram. Afterwards I will ask you to explain what changed between the two stages.”

Classroom example. In Drama, pupils shift from performance rehearsal to watching a demonstration. The teacher specifies the feature to attend to, then asks pupils to recall the key action and apply it in rehearsal. The attention habit supports access to the demonstration; visible posture alone is not treated as evidence that the performance technique was learned.

Top tips that make the technique work

Explain the purpose. A listening or viewing action is useful because it supports access to the idea, not because it looks compliant.

Name the relevant focus. Attention may belong on the model, speaker, diagram or text at different moments.

Practise the transition. Students need to switch attention fluently between writing, talk and shared explanation.

Check the message. Recall or application tells you more than posture, silence or nodding.

Avoid a rigid posture test. Use accessible ways of attending and do not treat direct eye contact as the only valid evidence.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Teach the action and its purpose.	Enforcing a posture checklist for its own sake.
Make the change of attentional focus explicit.	Expecting attentional routines to compensate for unclear explanation.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED — Habits of Attention